

UNIVERSITY OF ROSTOCK

Populist Rhetoric, Migration Wording of CDU Members and the 2025 AfD Popularity Surge

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1 Introduction

Germany has a significant amount of transnational migration. The high net migration rate is reflected in the share of immigrated people among Germany's population (Bundesministerium des Innern & Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge, 2025). While this is empirically evident, the cultural narrative regarding Germany's status and future as an "immigration country" ("Einwanderungsland") is frequently a topic of political and public debate (Kneuer et al., 2025).

Especially the "Christian Democratic Conservative Party", the CDU, which is one of the major established parties in Germany, has a dynamic evolution of its collective stance on migration.

In recent history, the CDU seems to be losing voters to the radical right-wing populist party (RRP) "Alternative für Deutschland" (AfD) and parts of the CDU may become more right leaning as a result (Baron & Görtz, 2023). This shows especially in the topic of migration, a central point in AfD's rhetoric. Consequently CDU members may adopt more populist and dramatizing rhetoric in that field of debate (Santoso, 2024).

In European politics, the surge in popularity of RRP and populist rhetoric poses a threat to inter- and intraparty democratic productivity and to the fairness of political competition (de Lange & Böckmann, 2025). While populist rhetoric is not problematic in itself, it is often exploited by RRP to promote anti-democratic discourse (Mudde, 2014).

Research thus needs to focus on the gap of understanding misused populist rhetoric and how it shapes the political landscape (Kollberg, 2025). This research report aims to contribute to this by answering the question: *"How has the wording regarding migration by CDU members changed in most recent history? How is this change in wording associated with the AfD's rise in popularity?"*.

The Research Report covers: Background and Literature, Methods and Analytical Strategy, Results, and a Discussion chapter.

2 Background and Literature

Existing theoretical and empirical literature provides tentative answers to the research question and may hint at which words to focally analyze.

CDU's history regarding migration is crucial context for the research question. Former Chancellor Angela Merkel's (CDU) 'Open Door Politics' during the Syrian refugee wave shifted the party's firm conservative identity towards a more liberal and multicultural stance (Bogado & Wolf, 2024; Hertner, 2021). Over time, however, and especially in recent history, the CDU became more right-leaning as well as more fragmented and polarized. This can be associated with the higher share of AfD seats in the last election (Anan, 2025).

The AfD's self-admitted Bundestag strategy, to force change in parliamentary discourse through radicalization and provocation may tie into this (Ruhose, 2018). A strong tie between AfD strategy and the behavior of established parties

also shows empirically, for example in Wordscore analysis of federal-state-level parliamentary transcripts: Research demonstrates convergence of the positions of established parties in parliamentary debates with the AfD (Atzpodien, 2022).

The research presented leads to the following tentative answers:

First: CDU wording has become more populist. Increases in emotionally loaded and polarizing language should be apparent.

Second: The CDU fears losing voters to the AfD. It is therefore expected to see a (positive) correlation between AfD popularity and an increase in CDU members' populist wording in the German Bundestag.

Regarding the selection of words for the analysis: migration might be framed (Müller & Mell, 2022) as "crisis" (Fröhlich, 2023), to misrepresent and dramatize its effects. So the German word "Migrationskrise" (migration crisis) will be focally analyzed.

3 Methods and Analytical Strategy

To operationalize AfD popularity, their share of Bundestag Seats at the 2025 election is indicated in analyses (20th German Bundestag: 83 seats (11.28%); 21st German Bundestag: 151 seats (23.97%)). Additionally, Forsa election poll data is taken into consideration (Forsa, n.d.-a, n.d.-b), to indicate the most recent AfD popularity trend. Forsa's methodology report only outlines a general approach to their research. The lack of scientifically correct documentation includes questionnaire design, weighting method, the exact sampling procedure, and other. The data is used to provide a rough estimation, which cannot be properly validated.

To analyze the wording trends, present German Bundestag corpora are not sufficiently up to date to answer the research question (Müller, 2023; Richter et al., 2023). Therefore, a custom dataset was analyzed. It contained all speeches and interjections from CDU members in official Bundestag transcripts ("Plenarprotokolle" (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.)) over 112 Sessions (from 21.09.2023 to 11.07.2025). The sessions are distributed roughly evenly across this time span.

To select migration related vocabulary, words that contained the consecutive letters "migr" within the dataset are analyzed. The code was written in hard-coded algorithms and is therefore transparent and deterministic. No specialized result validation needed to be conducted (Grimmer & Stewart, 2013). There was no Lemmatization of words, because the results were manually checked and adjusted.

An overview of the different word counts is given in the results section (see table 1, p. 4). For the most important of these words, dispersion over time is shown (see figure 2, p. 5): "Migrationskrise" and the ten most frequently used words are examined. A plot that indicates AfD popularity is given for context (see figure 1, p. 3).

This is a combined approach, deducing the focus on "Migrationskrise" from the literature while remaining open to inductively analyzing patterns that emerge

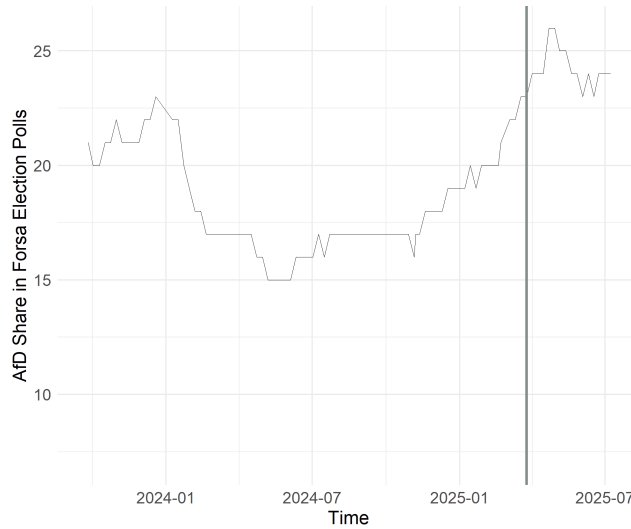
in the time trends (Salganik, 2019). Consequently, the literature regarding these findings must be discussed after the results are presented.

When comparing these CDU members' wording trends over time to the AfD popularity trend, patterns of association may become apparent.

4 Results

Figure 1 shows election poll results over time. The vertical line indicates the opening of the 21st German Bundestag and thus the 2025 election success of the AfD. One must keep in mind that election campaigns and public interest in politics may peak in the weeks and months before the election. The shape of the trajectory is U-shaped, with a small decline at the very end (Appendix A.1 shows the poll results over a longer time).

Figure 1. AfD Polling Trends During the Period Covered by the Analyzed Bundestag Transcripts.



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of Forsa election polls (Forsa, n.d.-b).

Figure: Own Figure.

Table 1 (p. 4) shows the count of the ten most frequent words containing *migr* within the data. Analysis showed, that important words to consider (please see below) were: "Migrationskrise" (n = 37), "Migrationswende" (Migration-Turn; n = 20) and "Remigration" (Remigration; n = 10).

Table 1. Most Frequently Used Migration-Related Terms in CDU Bundestag Speeches and Interjections.

Word	Word Count (% of Total)
Migration	391 (55,62%)
Migrationspolitik	155 (22,05%)
Migranten	44 (6,26%)
Migrationskrise	37 (5,26%)
Migrationshintergrund	23 (3,27%)
Migrationswende	20 (2,84%)
Remigration	10 (1,42%)
migrationspolitische	9 (1,28%)
Asylmigration	7 (1%)
Migrations- und Wirtschaftspolitik	7 (1%)
total	703

Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

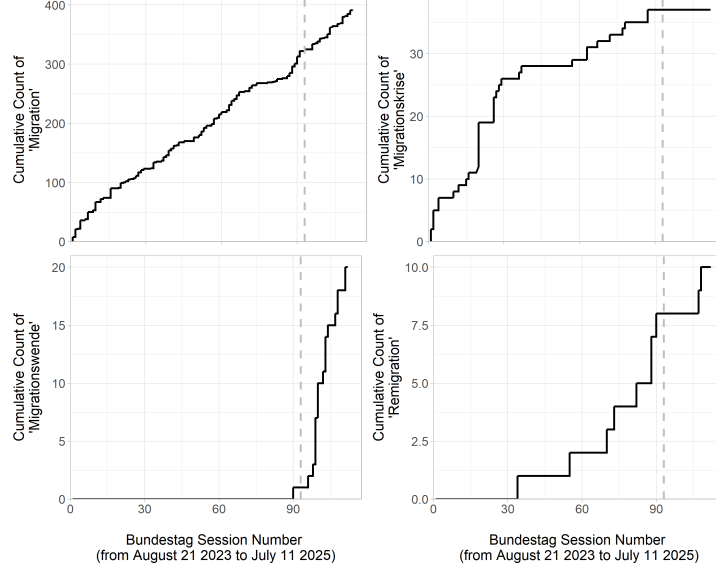
Among all of the plots for the individual use of words over time, "Migrationskrise", "Migrationswende" and "Remigration" showed patterns that do not scale proportionally with the amount of sessions. Proportional scaling would result in a linear diagonal line, which would mean, that the use of the word was distributed evenly across sessions.

Results are shown in Figure 2 (p. 5). "Migration" is added as a reference point with proportional scaling (note the differently scaled y-axes):

"Migration" was frequently used across time ($n = 391$), and its curve was fairly linear with a diagonal slope. "Migrationskrise" ($n = 37$) showed an increase in use between the first and 30th sessions, resulting in a locally steeper slope. The word "Migrationswende" ($n = 20$) first appeared around the 90th session, and was frequently used afterward, which results in a steep slope from that point on. "Remigration" ($n = 10$) was first used around the 30th session and showed an increase in use between the 70th and 90th sessions, resulting in a slightly steeper local slope. Plots of the remaining ten most frequent words - which are used evenly across sessions - are shown in Appendix B.1 to B.6.

"Migrations- und Wirtschaftspolitik" was excluded from the main Analysis. It showed disproportional use over time but has very few total occurrences, which are concentrated in only two sessions.

Figure 2. Cumulative Word Count of “Migration” (391), “Migrationskrise” (37), “Migrationswende” (20), and “Remigration” (10) in CDU Bundestag Speeches and Interjections across the 112 Sessions.



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

5 Discussion

The tentative answer that CDU wording has become more populist, and that this change is associated with AfD’s popularity, was partly supported by the analysis of the empirical data: The words “Migrationswende” and “Remigration” - both of which may be considered populist language - show an increase in use in recent Bundestag sessions:

“Migrationswende” semantically indicates a sudden and strong correction in migration policy. Its use trends may suggest that “Migrationswende” has been used much more frequently since the AfD’s 2025 election success. Existing literature interprets “Migrationswende” as “emphasis on illegitimacy and threat [and] Migrants framed as threats to public order”. Furthermore “Migrationswende” is marked among AfD’s top keywords in social media posts (Slowik, 2025, p. 24)(This seems to be the only research that explicitly mentions “Migrationswende”, it is a published bachelor’s thesis).

The described increase in the use of “Remigration” started at roughly 60 days before AfD’s election success, which may be considered the peak phase of

election campaigns. "Remigration" can be traced back by investigative journalism: the word is a term strategically reinvented and introduced into public discourse in RRP think tanks (Spieß, 2024). Both findings combined suggested a strong tie between the increasing use of the word and the AfD's political popularity and strategy.

However, "Migrationskrise" showed a decline in use over time, which did not align with existing research. Contrary to the tentative answers outlined, its decline seemed to correlate with the AfD's popularity evolution in election polls.

Conclusively, the research demonstrates strong examples in support of the tentative answers ("Migrationswende" and "Remigration"). Some developments may need further explanation ("Migrationskrise"). Inductively gained results highlight a blind spot in the literature: The relationship between the AfD's popularity and its strategic success remains largely unclear.

The research contributes small hints toward filling the gap in understanding how RRP and populist rhetoric influence Germany's Bundestag Discourse and the political landscape as a whole.

When reviewing the results, it is important to consider that migration-related words are only identified by their root. Vocabulary outside of that may also be used to describe migration. Furthermore, the context of the words used may not reflect their standalone meaning.

A central strength of the report is that it covers the most recent Bundestag protocols and election poll data. The full code is provided, reproducible, and designed to be scalable, given that the most recent data is provided. Lemmatization techniques may be introduced as best practice, when working with larger datasets. On the other hand, text analysis is limited to word count and dispersion over time, which is superficial but sufficient to provide a first answer to the research question and to expand on the literature.

Future research could specify results for individual speakers to take the heterogeneity of opinions within the party into account and/or make the analysis more context-sensitive by looking at Word Concordance of focally analyzed words.

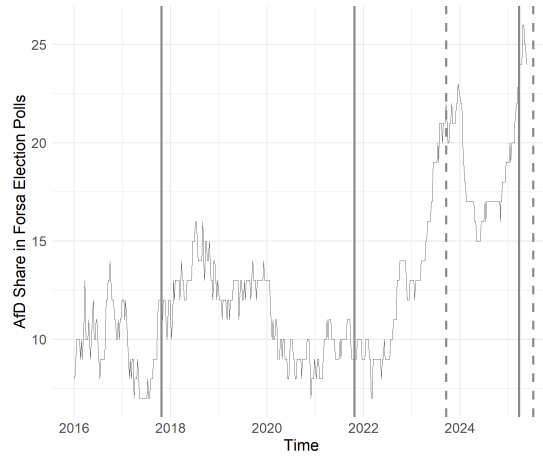
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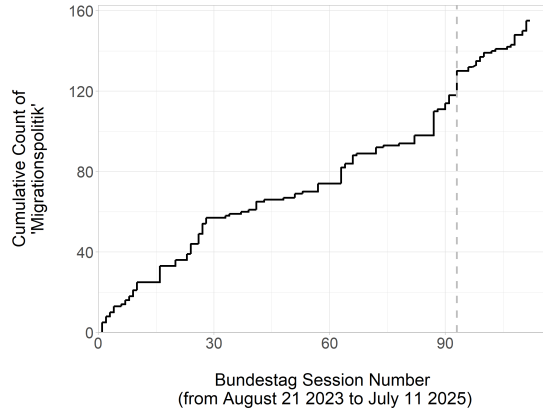
Appendix

Figure A.1. AfD Election Poll Results over Time Prior to and During the 19th–21st Bundestag (Vertical Lines Mark Bundestag Formations; Dotted Lines Indicate Transcript Dataset Range).



*Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag-Transcripts.
Figure: Own Figure.*

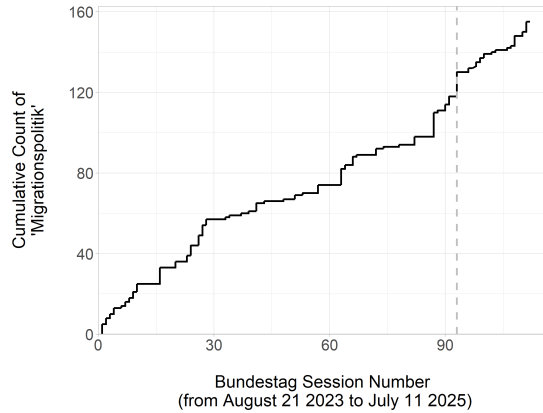
Figure B.1. Cumulative Word Count of “Migrationspolitik” in CDU Party Members’ German Bundestag Speeches and Interjections (155 Times Mentioned in 112 Bundestag Sessions).



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

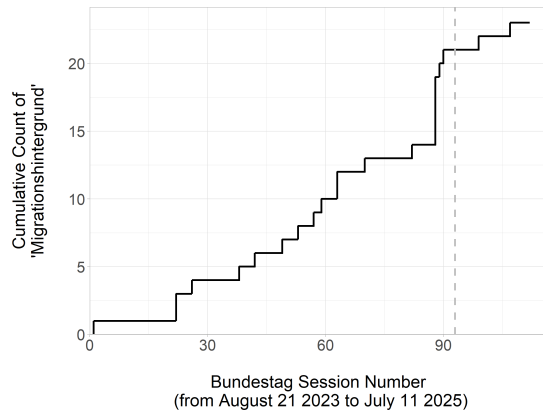
Figure B.2. Cumulative Word Count of ”Migranten” in CDU Party Members’ German Bundestag Speeches and Interjections (44 Times Mentioned in 112 Bundestag Sessions).



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

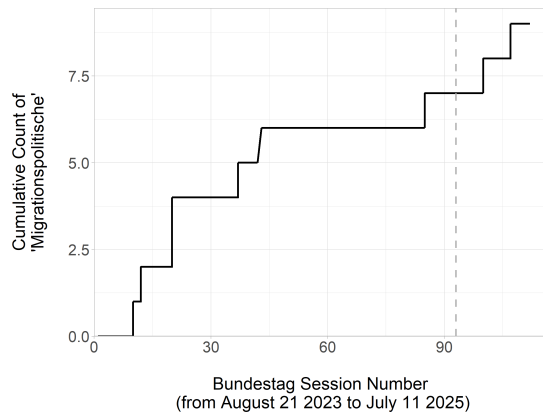
Figure B.3. Cumulative Word Count of "Migrationshintergrund" in CDU Party Members' German Bundestag Speeches and Interjections (23 Times Mentioned in 112 Bundestag Sessions).



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

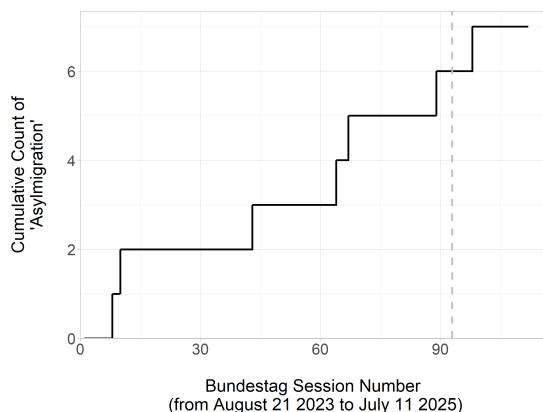
Figure B.4. Cumulative Word Count of "migrationspolitische" in CDU Party Members' German Bundestag Speeches and Interjections (9 Times Mentioned in 112 Bundestag Sessions).



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

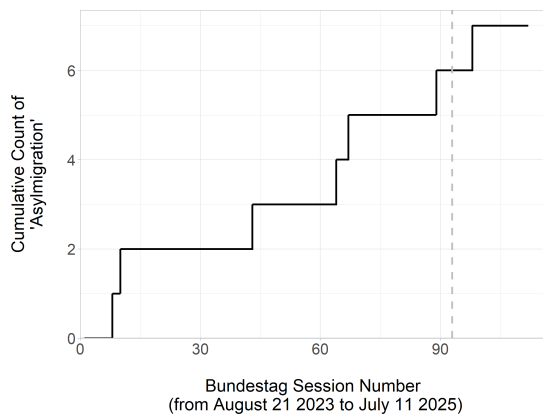
Figure B.5. Cumulative Word Count of "Asylmigration" in CDU Party Members' German Bundestag Speeches and Interjections (7 Times Mentioned in 112 Bundestag Sessions).



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

Figure B.6. Cumulative Word Count of "Migrations- und Wirtschaftspolitik" in CDU Party Members' German Bundestag Speeches and Interjections (7 Times Mentioned in 112 Bundestag Sessions).



Source: Own Calculations on the basis of official Bundestag Transcripts (Deutscher Bundestag [German Bundestag], n.d.).

Figure: Own Figure.

Zur Nutzung von KI in Hausarbeiten und Abschlussarbeiten

Mittlerweile sind die Einsatzmöglichkeiten von künstlicher Intelligenz (KI) im Schreibprozess sehr vielfältig. Sie darf jedoch nicht die Arbeit des Schreibens abnehmen, sondern nur gezielt als Werkzeug eingesetzt werden. Das wissenschaftliche Schreiben bleibt eine Kernkompetenz, die bei dem/der Autor:in liegen muss. Sie übernehmen die Verantwortung für die Texte, die Sie schreiben. Daher: Machen Sie die Nutzung von KI kenntlich! Sei es bei der Übersetzung von Texten, der stilistischen Überarbeitung oder der Generierung von Inhalten. Nutzen Sie dieses Formular mit angefügter Tabelle, um kenntlich zu machen, ob und wenn ja, welche KI-basierten Hilfsmittel eingesetzt wurden. Beschreiben Sie den Zweck des Einsatzes, nennen die betroffenen Teile der Arbeit und geben die verwendeten Prompts an. Wichtig ist: Ihre Eigenleistung muss erkennbar bleiben.

Bitte markieren Sie das Zutreffende:

- ☐ Ich habe bei der Erstellung dieses Textes kein KI-Tool verwendet
- ☒ Ich habe ein KI-Tool oder mehrere KI-Tools bei der Erstellung dieses Textes verwendet und habe die Nutzung dieser entsprechend dokumentiert

Wenn Sie ein KI-Tool verwendet haben, erklären Sie bitte, in welchen Teilen und wie KI zum Einsatz kam anhand der angefügten Tabelle.

Ich versichere, verwendete KI-Tools und deren Einsatz alle transparent angegeben und keine weiteren KI-Tools zur Erstellung, Strukturierung und/oder Überarbeitung der vorliegenden Arbeit eingesetzt zu haben (ggf. mehrere Seiten verwenden). Ich übernehme die volle Verantwortung für den Inhalt der abgelegten Arbeit.

Abgabedatum & -ort

28.08.2025, Rostock

Unterschrift Student:in



Dokumentation verwendeter KI-Tools

KI-basiertes Hilfsmittel	Zu welchem Zweck eingesetzt?	Betroffene Teile der Arbeit	Verwendete Prompts	Bemerkungen
ChatGPT 5.0	Code suggestions	R and Python Scripts	I'm working on a small python script, that can parse .xml data that is provided in a specific directory on the pc and returns a .csv file with information on speaker affiliation, a time proxy based on .xml file name, and speech paragraphs. Please refer me to first sources of official documentation, where I can learn about functions etc. for this.	Each part of the output is carefully reviewed and specifically adjusted to the individual use case. Code annotations in own words is given to demonstrate understanding of the final result.
ChatGPT 5.0	Debugging	R and Python Scripts	I run into the error message "XXX" when running my code. I was able to nail the problem down to this line of code "YYY" that refers to the dataframe "ZZZ" which is structured "AAA". Browsing error code discussion forums suggested that "BBB". Can you explain the discussed coding concept and apply it to my usecase. Give me hints how to fix the code.	Each step of the code is individually ran and preliminary results are checked in order to make sure, the code does as expected.

KI-basiertes Hilfsmittel	Zu welchem Zweck eingesetzt?	Betroffene Teile der Arbeit	Verwendete Prompts	Bemerkungen
ChatGPT 5.0	Latex Formatting	Latex Formatting	I am using "XXX" as my bibliography and citation style in Latex. I want to change it to APA. Can you tell me the differences in Latex coding between them, and point me to official documentation, where i can learn to apply APA style citation in Latex?	
ChatGPT 5.0	Correct Writing	Writing	This "XXX" is what I wrote in the first chapter of my assignment. Please go over it at tell me what is wrong regarding spelling and punctuation. I dont want correction on style or wording, only tell me what is plainly wrong.	All suggestions were individually considered, and not all were applied.

Eidesstattliche Versicherung

Ich versichere eidesstattlich durch eigenhändige Unterschrift, dass ich die Arbeit selbstständig und ohne Benutzung anderer als der angegebenen Hilfsmittel angefertigt habe. Alle Stellen, die wörtlich oder sinngemäß aus Veröffentlichungen entnommen sind, habe ich als solche kenntlich gemacht.

Die Arbeit ist noch nicht veröffentlicht und ist in gleicher oder ähnlicher Weise noch nicht als Studienleistung zur Anerkennung oder Bewertung vorgelegt worden. Ich weiß, dass bei Abgabe einer falschen Versicherung die Prüfung als nicht bestanden zu gelten hat.

Ort

(Abgabedatum)

(Vollständige Unterschrift)

Rostock

28.08.2025

